

Behavior and attitude

Overview of Attitude

To understand the meaning of attitudes, it can be helpful to look at a few different examples. Consider what your attitude is about the following:

- The death penalty
- Which political party does a better job of running the country
- Whether prayer should be allowed in schools
- Whether violence on television should be regulated

Chances are that you probably have fairly strong opinions on these and other similar topics. You've developed a passionate inner response about such issues, which can influence how you feel, what you do, and how you interact with people.

Attitudes are an important topic of study within the field of social psychology. But what exactly is an attitude? How does it develop?

How Psychologists Define Attitudes

Psychologists define attitudes as a learned tendency to view and judge things in a certain way. This can include an evaluation of people, issues, objects, policies, or events. It is an umbrella term that consists of our opinions, emotions, perceptions, beliefs, expectations, values, and intentions.¹

Such dispositions are often positive or negative, but they can also be uncertain or neutral at times. For example, you might have mixed feelings about a particular person or issue.

Researchers also suggest that there are three main dimensions that make up our attitudes.² The components of attitudes are sometimes referred to as the ABC's of attitude.

3 Components of Attitude

- **Affective Component:** How the object, person, issue, or event makes you feel.
- **Behavioral Component:** How you respond to someone or something that elicits a set of feelings and beliefs. This can be a verbal or a physical response.
- **Cognitive Component:** Your perception, ideas, and beliefs about the subject matter.

Attitudes can also be explicit and implicit.

- **Explicit attitudes** are those that we are consciously aware of and that clearly influence our emotional and behavioral reactions.
- **Implicit attitudes** are unconscious but still impact our emotions and behaviors.

Explicit Attitudes	Implicit Attitudes
Conscious Awareness: Explicit attitudes are consciously recognized and can be verbally expressed. Example: An Indian voter openly supporting a particular political party due to its policies.	Subconscious Nature: Implicit attitudes operate at a subconscious level and are not always accessible to conscious awareness. Example: Subtle preferences for certain political ideologies without conscious realization.
Deliberate Formation: These attitudes are often formed through direct experience or deliberate consideration. Example: Choosing vegetarianism in India after considering ethical and health aspects.	Automatic Formation: Formed through indirect experiences and associations, often without deliberate thought. Example: Subconsciously associating non-vegetarian food with certain social groups.
Easier to Change: Explicit attitudes can be changed with new information or persuasive communication. Example: Changing views on women's rights in India after exposure to feminist literature.	Resistant to Change: Implicit attitudes are more resistant to change as they are deeply ingrained. Example: Deep-seated, implicit gender biases influencing behaviour despite conscious support for gender equality.
Directly Measurable: Can be measured through surveys or self-reports. Example: Survey responses on attitudes towards caste-based reservations in India.	Indirect Measurement: Assessed through techniques like Implicit Association Tests (IAT). Example: Implicit biases towards caste or religion revealed through IAT.
Controlled Expression: Individuals can control how they express these attitudes. Example: Politely discussing religious beliefs in India, despite personal convictions.	Uncontrolled Influence: Often influence behaviour in an uncontrolled manner. Example: Subconscious discomfort in interfaith settings, despite conscious beliefs in religious tolerance.

Socially Influenced: Shaped by social norms and expectations. Example: Publicly endorsing secularism in India due to its social value.	Less Affected by Social Desirability: Less influenced by what is socially acceptable. Example: Implicit preferences for one's own religious group over others.
Reflects Current Beliefs: Represents an individual's current stance or belief. Example: Current support for environmental conservation movements in India.	May Not Reflect Current Beliefs: Can be remnants of past influences or upbringing. Example: Implicit attitudes towards environmental issues shaped by upbringing in a rural or urban setting.
Linked to Deliberate Actions: Often guide deliberate behaviours and choices. Example: Actively participating in India's Swachh Bharat (Clean India) campaign.	Influences Automatic Responses: Can subtly influence automatic responses or decisions. Example: Subconscious littering habits despite explicit support for cleanliness initiatives.
Subject to Social and Cultural Change: Can evolve with changing social and cultural norms. Example: Changing attitudes in India towards LGBTQ+ rights with evolving social norms.	Deeply Rooted: Often more stable and less susceptible to immediate social or cultural changes. Example: Implicit attitudes towards LGBTQ+ individuals influenced by traditional cultural upbringing.
Reflects Conscious Values: Aligned with an individual's consciously held values and ethics. Example: Explicit support for gender equality in the workplace in India.	May Conflict with Conscious Values: Can sometimes be at odds with an individual's explicit beliefs and values. Example: Implicit biases affecting hiring decisions, despite explicit beliefs in equality.

Attitude Formation

Several factors can influence how and why attitudes form, including:

Experience

Attitudes form directly as a result of personal experience with people, situations, objects, and ideologies. For example, you may experience a social interaction in a favorable way and form a positive attitude about that person, family, or group. On the other hand, you may have an unpleasant encounter that influences an unfavorable attitude.

Learning

Attitudes can be learned in a variety of ways.

- **Classical Conditioning:** Consider how advertisers use classical conditioning to influence your attitude toward a particular product. In a television commercial, you see young, beautiful people having fun on a tropical beach while enjoying a sports drink. This attractive and appealing imagery causes you to develop a positive association with this particular beverage.
- **Operant conditioning:** Consider how rewards and punishments can influence our attitudes (known as operant conditioning). Imagine a young man who has just started smoking. Whenever he lights up a cigarette, people complain, chastise him, and ask him to leave their vicinity. This negative feedback from those around him eventually causes him to develop an unfavorable opinion of smoking and he decides to give up the habit.
- **Observational learning:** Finally, people learn attitudes by observing people around them. When someone you admire greatly espouses a particular attitude, you are more likely to develop the same beliefs. For example, children spend a great deal of time observing the attitudes of their parents and usually begin to demonstrate similar outlooks. In addition, social media is having a profound influence on our attitudes as we are exposed to a variety of social media influencers.

Social and Cultural Factors

Social roles and cultural norms can have a strong influence on attitudes. Social roles relate to how people are expected to behave in a particular role or context. Cultural norms involve society's rules for what behaviors are considered appropriate.

Attitudes Impact on Behavior

We tend to assume that people behave according to their attitudes. However, social psychologists have found that attitudes and actual behavior are not always perfectly aligned.³

After all, plenty of people support a particular candidate or political party yet fail to vote. Some situations may evoke a strong passionate response, but the environment calls for self-control, professionalism, grace, and poise no matter how upset you may feel.

Essentially, people are more likely to behave according to their attitudes under certain conditions mitigated by personal values and social expectations.

Factors Influencing Attitude Strength

- You are an expert on the subject
- You experience something personally
- You expect a favorable outcome
- You stand to lose something due to the issue
- You have passion about the subject
- You are comfortable expressing your opinions

Why Attitudes Change

While attitudes can have a powerful effect on behavior, they are not set in stone. The same influences that lead to attitude formation can also create attitude change.⁴

Learning Theory

Classical conditioning, operant conditioning, and observational learning can be used to bring about attitude change.

- Classical conditioning can be used to create positive emotional reactions to an object, person, or event by associating positive feelings with the target object.
- Operant conditioning can be used to strengthen desirable attitudes and weaken undesirable ones.
- People can also change their attitudes after observing the behavior of others.

Elaboration Likelihood Theory

This theory of persuasion suggests that people can alter their attitudes in two ways.

1. They can be motivated to listen to an elaborate explanation and think about the message (central route persuasion), thus leading to an attitude shift.
2. They might be influenced by the likable characteristics of the speaker (peripheral route persuasion), leading to a temporary or surface shift in attitude.

Messages that are thought-provoking and that appeal to logic are more likely to lead to permanent changes in attitudes. **Cognitive Dissonance Theory**

Cognitive dissonance is a phenomenon in which a person experiences psychological distress due to conflicting beliefs and behaviors.⁵ To reduce this tension, people may change their attitudes to match their actual behaviors or alter their behavior to be more congruent with their beliefs.

Imagine that following situation: You've always placed a high value on financial security, but you start dating someone very financially unstable. You have two options to reduce the tension caused by conflicting beliefs and behavior. You can end the relationship and seek a more financially secure partner, or you can de-emphasize the importance of fiscal stability and focus on other important character traits instead.

Cognitive dissonance is the discomfort a person feels when their behavior does not align with their values or beliefs.

Cognitive dissonance is a psychological phenomenon that occurs when a person holds two contradictory beliefs at the same time.

Signs of cognitive dissonance

Because it is something a person feels internally, it is not possible to physically observe dissonance. As such, no set of external signs can reliably indicate a person is experiencing cognitive dissonance.

However, Festinger believed that all people are motivated to avoid or resolve cognitive dissonance due to the discomfort it causes. This can prompt people to adopt certain defense mechanisms when they have to confront it.

These defense mechanisms fall into three categories:

- **Avoiding:** This involves avoiding or ignoring the dissonance. People may avoid people or situations that remind them of it, discourage people from talking about it, or distract themselves with consuming tasks.
- **Delegitimizing:** This involves undermining evidence of the dissonance. A person may do this by discrediting the person, group, or situation that highlighted the dissonance. For example, they might say it is untrustworthy or biased.
- **Limiting impact:** This involves limiting the discomfort of cognitive dissonance by belittling its importance. A person may do this by claiming the behavior is rare or a oneoff event, or by providing rational arguments to convince themselves or others that the behavior is OK.

Alternatively, people may take steps to try to resolve the inconsistency. It is possible to resolve cognitive dissonance by either changing one's behavior or changing one's beliefs so they are consistent with each other.

Causes of cognitive dissonance

Anyone can experience cognitive dissonance. Sometimes, it is unavoidable.

People cannot always behave in a way that matches their beliefs. For example, a person may have to do something they disagree with at work.

Other potential triggers include:

- having to make a decision when presented with multiple options or information
- experiencing social pressure
- addiction, such as with smoking
- Effects of cognitive dissonance
- Cognitive dissonance can affect people in many ways. The effects may relate to the discomfort of the dissonance itself or the defense mechanisms a person adopts to deal with it.
- The internal discomfort and tension of cognitive dissonance could contribute to stress or unhappiness. People who experience dissonance but have no way to resolve it may also feel powerless or guilty.
- Avoiding, delegitimizing, and limiting the impact of cognitive dissonance may result in a person not acknowledging their behavior and thus not taking steps to resolve the dissonance. In some cases, this could cause harm to themselves or others.
- However, cognitive dissonance can also be a tool for personal and social change. Drawing a person's attention to the dissonance between their behavior and their values may increase their awareness of the inconsistency and empower them to act.

How to resolve cognitive dissonance

- **Changing their actions:** This involves changing behavior so it matches a person's beliefs. Where a full change is not possible, a person could make compromises. For instance, a person who cares about the environment but works for a company that pollutes might advocate for change at work if they cannot leave their job.
- **Changing their thoughts:** If a person often behaves in a way that contradicts their beliefs, they may question how important that belief is or find that they no longer believe it. Alternatively, they might add new beliefs that bring their actions closer to their thinking.
- **Changing their perception of the action:** If a person cannot or does not want to change the behavior or beliefs that cause dissonance, they may view the behavior differently instead. For example, a person who cannot afford to buy from sustainable brands might forgive themselves for this and acknowledge that they are doing the best they can.

Seeking help

Cognitive dissonance is not a mental health condition. A person does not necessarily need treatment for it.

However, if a person finds that they have difficulty stopping a behavior or thinking pattern that is causing them distress, they can seek support from a qualified healthcare professional, such as a primary care doctor or therapist.

A person may wish to consider reaching out to a professional if:

- they have an addiction
- the behavior causes problems at work, at school, or in relationships
- they feel stressed, anxious, or depressed
- they feel overwhelming guilt or shame

Approaches to Attitude Measurement Direct

Observation **itsceaobTwm**

This method involves recording the actual behaviour of people whose attitude is to be studied. It is indeed an objective method and well suited for certain kinds of issues. For example, it is quite commendable to observe the actual overt behaviour of strikers by participating in the strike itself to gain a measure of the strikers' attitude. We could also observe a company executive in his day-to-day dealings with his subordinates to assess his attitudes towards them. Even where accessibility is not a problem, direct observation of behaviour is not practicable if we want to have data on a large number of individuals. In addition to the difficulty of observing every individual in a large sample, there is no telling as to when an individual will exhibit the behaviour which is relevant to the study in question. even when we have managed to spot some behaviour related to our study, we do not know if the behaviour was an outcome of the related attitude or one caused by other factors. Take for instance a boy who goes to church regularly. You have observed his behaviour, all right. But, does this behaviour mean that he is favourably inclined toward prayer and religion? Not necessarily.

Direct Questioning

Direct questioning has had an appeal as a method of studying attitudes. But, however logical and smooth this technique may seem to be, it serves only a limited purpose of roughly classifying respondents as favourable, unfavourable, and indifferent with regard to a psychological object. Here we have the same problem as the one often encountered in direct observation; normally, neither direct observation nor direct questioning assesses the degree of attitudes an individual possesses. When controversial issues are involved and pressures and threats are operative, direct questioning is not the suitable means of data collection for assessing attitudes. Even when no threats are present, not all individuals are capable of articulating their feelings. A person may possess certain attitudes and behave accordingly, but may not be aware of them. Psycho-analysts have borne abundant witness to such phenomena. Thus, direct questioning or any other self-report technique will be of little avail if the respondent has no access to his own attitudinal orientations, buried in the realms of the unconscious

Scales of Measurement **agodpMm**

Measurement is assignment of mathematical symbols to objects and events according to rules. In order to assign different symbols to different objects, one must be able to differentiate objects on a given aspect, attribute or property.

Thurston scale

It has a number of agree or disagree statements.

It is to measure the willingness of members of different ethnic groups to associate with each other.

It measures the social distance between two or more social groups by having members of one group indicate the limit of their comfort with various types of social interaction or closeness with members of other groups.

You prepare set of questions in form of yes or No. then results are compiled based on this

Understanding stereotypes, prejudice and discrimination

Everyone has different beliefs, experiences, abilities, appearances and more. However, certain people and groups are more likely to experience stereotypes, prejudice and discrimination.

They may be targeted because of their:

- abilities • age
- economic status
- ethnicity and/or race
- gender identity or expression
- national origin
- physical appearance
- religion • sexual orientation • etc.

Stereotypes, prejudice and discrimination often come from:

- inequalities in society
- ideas learned about other people/groups from family members, friends and/or the media
- not spending a lot of time with people who are different from you in some way
- not being open to different ideas and ways of living

A stereotype is an assumption

A stereotype means assuming that a group of people who share some characteristics also share certain attributes. In other words, when someone assumes something about you because of one part of your identity. Stereotypes are often:

- negatively impactful
- overly simplistic
- dangerous
- unfair

Prejudice is a belief

Prejudice is when someone has a belief (usually negative) about a person or group based on a stereotype. The belief is usually based on a person's membership (or assumed membership) in a certain group. Prejudice also divides people based on stereotypes. Examples include:

- **Ableism:** negative attitudes based on physical and/or mental abilities.
- **Cissexism:** negative attitudes toward people who don't identify with the sex they were assigned at birth.
- **Homophobia:** negative attitudes toward members of the 2SLGBTQ+ community.
- **Racism:** negative attitudes based on race, ethnicity and/or culture.
- **Sexism:** negative attitudes based on gender identity, gender expression and/or sex assigned at birth.
- **Xenophobia:** negative attitudes based on national origin/country.

Discrimination is an action

Discrimination is when someone acts on their prejudiced beliefs. It can also be systemic, like the policies and practices put in place to assimilate First Nations, Inuit and Métis peoples. Examples of discrimination include:

- a manager promoting a cisgender employee over a transgender employee whose performance is stronger
- a racialized youth being monitored without cause while shopping in a store
- a health-care provider refusing to treat/diagnose a patient who is part of a particular racial/ethnic group

What are the negative effects of stereotypes, prejudice and discrimination on mental health?

People may experience mental ill-health and other challenges as a result of stereotypes, prejudice and discrimination. People who are the targets of stereotypes, prejudice and discrimination may:

- have low self-esteem
- experience mental disorders such as anxiety, depression or post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD)
- begin to believe negative stereotypes about themselves
- experience intergenerational trauma
- feel like they lack control of their own life
- experience issues at school and/or work (e.g. bullying, harassment, etc.)
- start to lose hope in the future
- experience loneliness and isolation
- feel like they're unable to trust others
- experience physical effects (e.g. trouble sleeping, etc.)

What can I do about stereotypes, prejudice and discrimination?

You can help reduce stereotypes, prejudice and discrimination. Here are some ways you can take a stand:

- reflect on your own ideas and actions to see if you have prejudiced attitudes or act in discriminatory ways (either on purpose or unintentionally)
- don't laugh at jokes that are based on stereotypes
- refuse to watch movies, read books, play video games or participate in activities promoting negative attitudes toward certain groups of people
- challenge peers/family who express prejudiced beliefs, if it's safe to do so (you could share this article with them as a starting point)
- support organizations that help address the root causes and effects of stereotypes, prejudice and discrimination

Persuasive Communication

What Is Persuasion?

Persuasion is a process in which one person or entity tries to influence another person or group of people to change their beliefs or behaviors. It is distinct from coercion, in that the people receiving the message have a choice about whether to act on it.¹ ("Coercive persuasion" refers to indoctrination or brainwashing,² such as may occur in a cult.)

Persuasion can be a powerful force that affects the decisions and actions that people take. Persuasive messages are symbolic (using words, images, and sounds) and may be transmitted verbally or nonverbally, via media or face-to-face communication. Persuasion may be overt or subtle.

Uses

Advertisements that urge viewers to buy a particular product are a form of persuasion. So are political debates, where candidates try to sway voters to their side. Persuasion is a powerful force in daily life and has a major influence on society and a whole.

Negative examples of persuasion often come to mind—as in an ad trying to get you to buy something you don't need, [peer pressure](#) that causes you to make a poor decision, or even deliberate misinformation. But persuasion can also be used in a positive way: Think of public service or health campaigns that urge people to recycle, [quit smoking](#), or practice [social distancing](#) to help protect themselves and their community.

Theories of persuasive communication

Social Judgment Theory

Muzafer Sherif and Carl Hovland created social judgment theory in an attempt to determine what types of communicative messages and under what conditions communicated messages will lead

to a change in someone's behavior (Sherif & Hovland, 1961). In essence, Sherif and Hovland found that people's perceptions of attitudes, values, beliefs, and behaviors exist on a continuum including latitude of rejection, latitude of noncommitment, and latitude of acceptance.

Latitudes of Judgments

Imagine that you are planning to persuade your peers to major in a foreign language in college. Some of the students in your class may disagree with you right off the bat, representing the latitude of rejection. Other students may think majoring in a foreign language is a great idea, representing the latitude of acceptance. Still others are really going to have no opinion either way, representing the latitude of noncommitment. Within each of these different latitudes there is a range of possibilities. For example, one of your listeners may be perfectly willing to accept the idea of minoring in a foreign language, but when asked to major or even double major in a foreign language, he or she may end up in the latitude of noncommitment or even rejection.

Not surprisingly, Sherif and Hovland found that persuasive messages are the most likely to succeed when they fall into an individual's latitude of acceptance.

Sherif and Hovland theorized that persuasion is a matter of knowing how great the discrepancy or difference is between the speaker's viewpoint and that of the audience. If the speaker's point of view is similar to that of audience members, then persuasion is more likely. If the discrepancy between the idea proposed by the speaker and the audience's viewpoint is too great, then the likelihood of persuasion decreases dramatically.

Discrepancy and Attitude Change

There comes a point where the discrepancy between the speaker and audience member becomes too large, which moves into the options that will be automatically rejected by the audience member. In essence, it becomes essential for you to know which options you can realistically persuade your audience to and which options will never happen.

Cognitive Dissonance Theory

In 1957, Leon Festinger proposed another theory for understanding how persuasion functions. Cognitive dissonance is an aversive motivational state that occurs when an individual entertains two or more contradictory attitudes, values, beliefs, or behaviors simultaneously. For example, maybe you know you should be working on your speech, but you really want to go to a movie with a friend. In this case, practicing your speech and going to the movie are two cognitions that are inconsistent with one another. The goal of persuasion is to induce enough dissonance in listeners that they will change their attitudes, values, beliefs, or behaviors.

Frymier and Nadler (2007) noted that for cognitive dissonance to work effectively there are three necessary conditions: **aversive consequences**

for cognitive dissonance to work, the punishment associated with not eating apples needs to be significant enough to change behaviors. If you convince your audience that without enough fiber in their diets they are at higher risk for heart disease or colon cancer, they might fear the aversive consequences enough to change their behavior.

The second condition necessary for cognitive dissonance to work is that people must have a **freedom of choice**. As a speaker, if you want to increase cognitive dissonance, you need to make sure that your audience does not feel coerced or manipulated, but rather that they can clearly see that they have a choice of whether to be persuaded.

The final condition necessary for cognitive dissonance to work has to do with **external and internal justifications**. External justification refers to the process of identifying reasons outside of one's own control to support one's behaviors, beliefs, and attitudes. Internal justification occurs when someone voluntarily changes a behavior, belief, or attitude to reduce cognitive dissonance. When it comes to creating change through persuasion, external justifications are less likely to result in change than internal justifications.

Elaboration Likelihood Model

The term elaboration refers to the amount of thought or cognitive energy someone uses for analyzing the content of a message. High elaboration uses the central route and is designed for analyzing the content of a message. As such, when people truly analyze a message, they use cognitive energy to examine the arguments set forth within the message. In an ideal world, everyone would process information through this central route and actually analyze arguments presented to them. Unfortunately, many people often use the peripheral route for attending to persuasive messages, which results in low elaboration or thought. Low elaboration occurs when people attend to messages but do not analyze the message or use cognitive energy to ascertain the arguments set forth in a message.

Frymier and Nadler discussed five basic factors that can lead to high elaboration

Personal Relevance and Personal Involvement

The first reason people are motivated to take the central route or use high elaboration when listening to a persuasive message involves personal relevance and involvement. Personal relevance refers to whether the audience member feels that he or she is actually directly affected by the speech topic. For example, if someone is listening to a speech on why cigarette smoking is harmful, and that listener has never smoked cigarettes, he or she may think the speech topic simply is not relevant. Obviously, as a speaker you should always think about how your topic is relevant to your listeners and make sure to drive this home throughout your speech

Accountability

The second condition under which people are likely to process information using the central route is when they feel that they will be held accountable for the information after the fact. With accountability, there is the perception that someone, or a group of people, will be watching to see if the receiver remembers the information later on.

Personal Responsibility

When people feel that their evaluation is important, they take more responsibility and, therefore, are more critical of the message delivered.

Incongruent Information

Some people are motivated to centrally process information when it does not adhere to their own ideas. you are more likely to pay attention to the speech, specifically looking for flaws in the speaker's argument.

Need for Cognition

Need for cognition refers to a personality trait characterized by an internal drive or need to engage in critical thinking and information processing. People who are high in need for cognition simply enjoy thinking about complex ideas and issues. Even if the idea or issue being presented has no personal relevance, high need for cognition people are more likely to process information using the central route.

